

Trump Shields
A Weedkiller,
And a Weapon

Cites U.S. Security in an
Order on Phosphorus

By HIROKO TABUCHI

When President Trump issued an abrupt order last month compelling the production of glyphosate, the controversial weed-killer known as Roundup, he angered health activists who have long campaigned to ban the product for its links to cancer.

But largely overshadowed in the furor was the order's mention of something contentious in another way: the manufacture of munitions used by the United States military.

Bayer, which makes glyphosate, is also the only company in the United States that manufactures a form of elemental phosphorus called white phosphorus, which it uses to make the weed-killer. That white phosphorus is also used to make munitions deployed as smoke screens and incendiary devices that can violently burn property or people.

Concerns about the availability of phosphorus for defense played a significant role in Mr. Trump's move to deem Bayer's operations a national security priority, according to two people with direct knowledge of the administration's deliberations. One of the individuals also stressed its importance in light of recent United States military actions.

When asked about the significance of munitions in the Trump executive order, Karoline Leavitt, the White House press secretary, said in a phone call, "The president made this decision based on national security priorities." She added that the administration is funding research into alternatives to the herbicide glyphosate.

Bayer's place in America's military and industrial supply chain is a little-known aspect of a German company that's behind household pharmaceuticals including Aspirin and Alka-Seltzer. White phosphorus ignites spontaneously when it comes in contact with oxygen. It produces a thick white smoke and can reach temperatures high enough to burn through metal.

Bayer, through its acquisition of Monsanto in 2018, operates the only facility in the United States that produces white phosphorus. It is in Soda Springs, Idaho, and uses phosphate rock the company mines locally.

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IRAN PICKS SLAIN AYATOLLAH'S SON TO LEAD



Smoke rose on Sunday from an oil storage center in Tehran. The appointment of Mojtaba Khamenei as Iran's leader, announced on Monday, caused oil prices to spike.

A Week of Battle Punishes Iran,
But No Final Goal Is Apparent

This article is by Mark Mazzetti, Tyler Pager, Ronen Bergman, Farnaz Fassihi, Eric Schmitt, Erika Solomon and Julian E. Barnes.

WASHINGTON — The volley of Israeli missiles that slammed into a government compound in central Tehran early on Feb. 28 was by any military standard a successful opening strike by the United States and Israel as they went to war with Iran.

The blasts killed Iran's supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, as well as a cadre of other senior military and intelligence officials. The war's first salvo left Iran without many of its top commanders to lead the response.

The reckoning, it turned out,

was more complicated. The Israeli strike also killed another group of Iranian officials who had been meeting in a different part of the compound. Among them were people the White House had identified as more willing to negotiate than their bosses, and who might help bring a swift end to the conflict, according to American officials.

The strike on the compound in Tehran was emblematic of the muddled reality of the war's first week: a withering air campaign by American and Israeli forces against an overwhelmed enemy, but few answers about what victory might look like. Iran, its government still in place, has re-

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In New World of War Drones,
U.S. Builds on Iranian Design

By PAUL MOZUR and ADAM SATARIANO

Long before Iranian drones rained down on airports, skyscrapers and embassies across the Persian Gulf this past week, the United States military was busy trying to find cheap ways to shoot them down.

In 2024, the military's research and development effort reverse-engineered the Shahed drone to use for target practice, aiming to develop new defenses against a weapon that Iran had been sharing with allies including Russia, Venezuela and Hezbollah.

Then came an idea. If the Iranian drone was so cheap and effective, why not just copy it?

Thus was born the United

States low-cost unmanned combat system, or LUCAS. Over the past week, American forces used the drone for the first time in combat to hit infrastructure and overwhelm Iranian air defense systems.

"These low-cost drones, modeled after Iran's Shahed drones, are now delivering American-made retribution," the U.S. Central Command said in a social media post.

The dueling drones have become a defining feature of the war with Iran. It is a glimpse of a future in which the ability to use new technologies, rapidly copy adver-

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Despite Warning,
Clerics Choose
Hard-Liner

By FARNAZ FASSIHI and THOMAS FULLER

Iran named Mojtaba Khamenei, a son of the recently killed supreme leader, as his father's successor, signaling the continuity of hard-line theocratic rule amid war with the United States and Israel.

The announcement, which was made in a statement from top clerics published on state media early Monday local time, came in defiance of President Trump, who said last week that naming Mr. Khamenei to the post would be unacceptable.

As rumors had circulated across Iran about the decision on Sunday, viscous plumes of black smoke billowed above Tehran after Israeli strikes ignited fuel depots.

Signaling no letup in a war that has spread across the Middle East, the United States Central Command on Sunday issued a stark order to the 90 million residents of Iran to "stay at home."

And in a sign of the growing risks around the region, American employees of the U.S. diplomatic mission in Saudi Arabia were given mandatory departure orders, according to six current and former U.S. officials. The Pentagon announced a U.S. service member had died in the conflict from injuries sustained in Saudi Arabia, the seventh death of American military personnel since the war began.

In the hours after Mr. Khamenei's appointment was announced, oil prices surged over 10 percent, with international prices crossing \$100 a barrel for the first time in almost four years.

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Mojtaba Khamenei

Gadget for School Phone Bans
Beat by Rocks, Pupils, Scissors

By MADISON MALONE KIRCHER and CALLIE HOLTERMANN

One day last February, Joel Nam, a student at Van Nuys High School in Los Angeles, emerged from class at lunchtime and heard a sharp banging noise echoing around the quad.

That morning, his school had distributed Yondr pouches, fabric smartphone pockets that schools around the country are using to enforce bell-to-bell cellphone bans. Some four hours later at Van Nuys, students had figured out that whacking the pouches against tables and railings at a particular angle would cause them to spring open, freeing the smartphones trapped inside.

Soon, Joel's classmates had figured out that a strong magnet available on Amazon could unlock the pouches, too, he said. "A lot of kids picked rocks up off the ground, flat rectangular rocks, and just slipped them in," said Joel, 18, a senior. "You can't tell if it's a phone or not."

It's a classic tale of a sophisticated object brought down by simple means. iPhone, meet drop of water. Cybertruck window, meet steel ball. Yondr pouch, meet powerful magnet. Or tree. Or rock. Or scissors.

Some might have found it mildly amusing, how easily the best-laid plans by adults had been undone by the ingenuity of teenagers. Joel, writing for his school paper, took a different view. The

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Yondr's pouches are a de facto solution to school phone bans.



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Portraits as Projections of Power

Never before has a sitting president displayed so much of his image on the White House walls. President Trump's visage has also appeared in unexpected places. Pages A12-13.

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ICE Agents Detain Reporter

The arrest in Nashville of the Colombian immigrant raised fears that she had been targeted for her coverage of the immigration crackdown. PAGE A16

Economic Alarms Sound

With jobs numbers and markets down, and gas prices rising, Republicans should worry. News Analysis. PAGE A14

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Singer of Antiwar Anthem

With his "I-Feel-Like-I'm-Fixin'-to-Die Rag," Country Joe McDonald protested the Vietnam War. He was 84.

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Landslide Win for Ex-Rapper

A youth-led uprising brought down Nepal's government. Now a 35-year-old is set to become its leader. PAGE A9

The 'Politics of Small Deeds'

Residents of St. Petersburg, Russia, find purpose and community in repairing architectural treasures. PAGE A10



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A Deeply Personal A.I. Rivalry

A fight over contracts with the Pentagon shows how the leaders of OpenAI and Anthropic are feuding over the future of the tech industry. PAGE B1

Pivotal Time for Automakers

With tariffs and the rise of China, industry veterans say they cannot remember when U.S. carmakers faced as much uncertainty as they do now. PAGE B1

Spate of F.D.A. Drug Denials

Officials promise fast reviews of new treatments, but patients with rare diseases view recent moves as signs that their options are narrowing. PAGE B1

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A Whole Other Ballgame

For some women's college basketball players who come from overseas, their first love was netball. PAGE D1

No-Looks and New Looks

Coach Emma Hayes's rebuild of the U.S. women's soccer team is taking shape — and already reaping rewards. PAGE D2



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The Met Opera's Cash Crunch

The company has looked far and wide (including outer space) in its scramble to find operating money. PAGE C1

Sale of Friars Club Treasures

A host of showbiz-related items, including Jack Benny's violin and a trunk full of old jokes, were auctioned. PAGE C1

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Daryl Hannah

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